



Rs 1,250

+ Well build

- Poor performance

44.1

17.7

20.0

6.4

800 x 600

800 x 600

x

4.0

x

x/✓/x

✓

✓

✓

x

NA

1.48 m

x

Windows 2000/XP
AmCap/Web Eye/VP
Eye / VP Hotline

5.0

7.0

5.0

6.0

4.0

4.5

4.5

4.5

4.0

4.0

5.0

4.0

5.0

**Logitech QuickCam Messenger**

Price that pierces the performance shield

With the Zebronics 350 WC, the problem was that all the light fell on a particular part of the subject. The performance of the ZENX was comparable to that of the Zebronics 1300 WC; colour reproduction took a small hit, though.

PERFORMANCE WEBCAMS

Webcams in the Rs 1,701 to 3,000 category sport superior build quality. Use of better-quality lenses and CMOS sensors ensure better performance compared to the earlier categories. The cameras in this category are not fast movers on shop counters. Bandwidth-intensive streaming like videoconferencing being buyers' chief applications, so a better-quality picture at high resolutions are demanded. We reviewed five webcams here, with Microsoft, Logitech, and Creative with one contestant each, and two from Genius.

Features

The Genius Look 313 Media is a feature-rich, multifunctional device: it flaunts a 2-watt RMS stereo speaker, a USB hub, headphones, and a microphone socket. The Genius—the Look 310S is the smallest camera we received; it uses a screw to clamp onto LCD panels. The Microsoft VX-3000 implements a Live! Call button.

The Clamp

The Creative Live! IM Pro and the Logitech have well-designed clamps; few problems clamping onto thicker LCD bezels. The Genius Look 310S uses a screw mechanism as a clamp: the small clipping width precludes it clamping to some Desktop LCD monitors, but is good enough for most laptops.

Enhancements

Logitech features RightSound in the QuickCam IM: this reduces background sound by using compensation for the feedback received from the mic. Creative's Live View Auto Tuning technology automatically adjusts exposure in real-time, meaning better images. The Creative Live! IM Pro and Microsoft VX-

3000 both support face tracking, this tracks face movement and generates a frame in which the subject's face is prominent. The face tracking mechanism on the Creative has an edge over the Microsoft.

Accessories

All manufactures have future-proofed their products, having incorporated Vista support in the drivers. The DDPlayCam software, though feature-rich, has a comparatively poor interface. Creative and Logitech bundle a highly usable package. Both the Genius webcams have a detachable mini USB connector.

The Logitech QuickCam IM comes bundled with a monoaural headphone and microphone combination (153 cm long); Creative provides a similar ear-set made of rubber with its Live! IM Pro. Genius bundles a microphone with the Look 310S. The Genius Look 313 Media has headphone and microphone-out jacks. The unshielded speakers of the Genius Look 313 Media cause gaussing of CRTs: not for CRT owners!

Aesthetics And Build Quality

The Microsoft VX-3000 is the best looker here. The Genius Look Media has two foldable speakers, so you can have them point forwards or to the sides, as your tastes dictate. The Creative Live! IM Pro is slim and tall.

Logitech has the best build quality in this class. Microsoft and Creative follow closely, and are similar. The plastic used in the Genius is slightly below par. The Genius Look 310S is slightly unstable due to its small base; the Genius Look 313 Media provides slightly better stability than the Look 310S due to its larger base. Creative and Logitech pose minimal problems regarding stability, but the smaller base in the case of Microsoft's webcam means less stability.

**Logitech QuickCam IM**

Price and performance none can match